

THE WAY

Companion Formation Curriculum

Seeker Orientation, Companion Foundations, Year One, continuing formation,
children/youth, and ministry pathways

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This curriculum teaches the Way without making religious commitment a prerequisite for learning. Completion never creates spiritual rank, employment rights, statutory membership, or an obligation to accept ministry.

1. Curriculum design rules

- Questions are legitimate learning outcomes, not disciplinary problems.
- Each module should distinguish evidence, testimony, interpretation, teaching, and open questions.
- Practice and service accompany study so formation does not collapse into information transfer.
- No module requires disclosure of trauma, sexuality, finances, family secrets, mental health history, or private religious experience.
- Assessments measure understanding or skill, not spiritual worth.
- A learner may stop at any point without social penalty.

2. Seeker Orientation - six sessions

Session	Theme	Core content	Practice / assignment
1	What is the Way?	Whole-system map; Way/Companion/Assembly/House distinction; beginning/end.	Attend one Gathering; reflection on personal questions.
2	Why study humanity's religious inheritance?	Encounter, testimony, history, comparative method, source humility.	Compare two accounts of one religious event/figure.
3	What do Companions actually do?	Sevenfold practice: attention, prayer, study, discernment, ethics, service, companionship.	Try one brief daily practice for a week.
4	Freedom of conscience and institutional integrity	Member rights, founder limits, complaints, exit, safeguarding, money/power boundaries.	Read participant rights; identify one safeguard that matters to you.
5	What does the Way currently teach?	Confidence levels, current ethical commitments, major open questions.	Choose an open question and map evidence needed.
6	What would becoming a Companion mean?	Companion Commitment, Rule of Life, no statutory membership, free exit.	Optional conversation; no decision expected at session end.

3. Companion Foundations - twelve modules

ID	Module	Core content	Practice / evidence
CF-01	Reality, truth, humility	Why reality precedes institution; confidence levels; intellectual honesty.	Attention practice + question journal.
CF-02	Encounter and testimony	Religious experience; memory; testimony; evidence; interpretation.	Analyze one historical testimony.
CF-03	Sacred sources	Library of Witnesses; provenance; translation; textual history.	Build a source record.
CF-04	Prayer	Seven movements of prayer; silence; fixed/free prayer; conscience.	Morning/evening practice experiment.
CF-05	Ethics and power	Dignity, truth, non-coercion, justice/mercy, repair, conflicts.	Case study.

ID	Module	Core content	Practice / evidence
CF-06	Jesus and the early Jesus movement	Historical questions and major theological claims without forced conclusion.	Source comparison.
CF-07	Muhammad and early Islam	Qur'anic claim, prophetic identity, community formation, interpretive tradition.	Primary/secondary source comparison.
CF-08	Buddha and paths of awakening	Suffering, ethics, meditation, non-self/impermanence claims, communities of practice.	Practice/claim distinction exercise.
CF-09	Israel, covenant, prophecy, wisdom	Hebrew Bible/Israelite-Jewish inheritance; covenant, law, prophets, wisdom, prayer.	Timeline + theme map.
CF-10	Assembly and companionship	Mutual care, discernment, disagreement, belonging, exit, service.	Participate in service or Common Table.
CF-11	Open theology	God, salvation/liberation, death, scripture, evil, family/sexual ethics, violence.	Choose one question and produce a balanced inquiry memo.
CF-12	Rule of Life and Companion Commitment	Design a sustainable personal rhythm; understand voluntary commitment.	Draft personal Rule of Life; commitment remains optional.

4. Year One Companion Cycle

Quarter	Formation focus	Outputs
Quarter 1 - Attend and Pray	Establish daily attention/prayer; learn House rhythm; basic sacred-source method.	Prayer journal; one source dossier; regular gathering participation as able.
Quarter 2 - Study and Discern	Deepen comparative/historical literacy; practice discernment and ethical case analysis.	Study project; discernment observation; ethics reflection.
Quarter 3 - Serve and Accompany	Charitable/service practice; hospitality; mutual care; understand safeguarding and boundaries.	Service project; Common Table support; safeguarding refresher.
Quarter 4 - Integrate and Transmit	Review Rule of Life; articulate what is believed/unknown; practice explaining the Way accurately.	Personal review; teach/facilitate a short supervised session if desired.

5. Continuing formation

- Annual theme cycle: one major source tradition, one ethical issue, one practice discipline, one service focus.
- At least one structured retreat/reflection period each year when health and circumstances permit.
- Annual review of personal Rule of Life without submission to intrusive surveillance.
- Periodic historical/source-method refresh so inherited stories do not become detached from evidence.
- Optional advanced seminars in languages, philosophy, comparative theology, science/religion, ethics, history, pastoral care, or community service.

6. Children and youth curriculum map

Band	Theme	Content	Methods
Ages 3-6	Wonder and care	Gratitude; nature; kindness; simple prayer; safe adults; stories from many traditions clearly identified.	Art, song, movement, story, family service.
Ages 7-10	Stories and virtues	Abraham, Moses, prophets, Jesus, Muhammad, Buddha and others as historically situated figures/traditions; truthfulness about uncertainty.	Maps, timelines, projects, simple source comparison.
Ages 11-13	Questions and discernment	How traditions form; evidence vs interpretation; ethical reasoning; digital/media literacy; boundaries/consent.	Debate, journaling, service, source packets.
Ages 14-17	Inquiry and vocation	Historical criticism; philosophy; theology; science/religion; ethics; service leadership; governance/integrity.	Seminar papers, supervised facilitation, service practicum.

7. Teacher formation pathway

1. Complete Companion Foundations or demonstrate equivalent understanding.
2. Demonstrate subject competence and ability to distinguish source, interpretation, teaching, and open question.
3. Complete basic pedagogy, accessibility, child/adult safeguarding as applicable, and anti-coercion training.
4. Prepare lesson plans that include competing interpretations where materially relevant.
5. Teach under supervision; receive learner and supervisor feedback.
6. Receive a written scope of teaching authorization, term, review date, and complaint route.
7. Renew through continuing study and periodic review.

8. Minister formation pathway

Module	Title
MF-01	Theology of ministry and limits of spiritual authority
MF-02	Prayer, worship, ritual, and public religious leadership
MF-03	Pastoral listening, grief, crisis, and referral
MF-04	Safeguarding and mandatory reporting
MF-05	Sexual/relational boundaries and dual relationships
MF-06	Confidentiality, records, and privacy
MF-07	Conflict, discipline, reconciliation, and non-retaliation
MF-08	Sacred-source method and teaching integrity
MF-09	Interreligious literacy and respectful difference
MF-10	Institutional governance, money, gifts, and conflicts
MF-11	Supervised practicum

Module	Title
MF-12	Commissioning review and continuing formation plan

Recommended working minimum before first commissioning: completion of relevant modules, role-specific safeguarding/background review, supervised practicum with documented feedback, and independent approval under the commissioning process. No fixed hour count is adopted yet; pilot data should inform v1.0 requirements.

9. Assessment philosophy

- Use understanding checks, practical demonstrations, source-analysis assignments, reflective writing, supervised practice, and case exercises.
- Do not use confessional tests to compel assent to open or provisional questions.
- A ministry candidate may be unsuitable for office because of competency, boundary, or integrity concerns without being treated as spiritually inferior.
- Learner records should minimize sensitive information and follow a retention policy.

Appendix. Formation record templates

- Seeker Orientation completion record (attendance/understanding only; not membership).
- Companion Foundations module record.
- Personal Rule of Life worksheet.
- Source-analysis worksheet.
- Service reflection record.
- Teaching practicum observation.
- Minister practicum supervision record.
- Annual continuing-formation plan.